COUNTERSPELL (5E, 2024 RULES) – DESCRIPTION

Level 3 – Abjuration
Casting Time: **Reaction**, which you take when you see a creature within 60 feet casting a spell with Verbal, Somatic, or Material components · Range: 60 feet
Components: **S** · Duration: Instantaneous
Classes: Sorcerer, Warlock, Wizard

You attempt to **interrupt** a creature in the process of casting a spell. The creature makes a **Constitution saving throw** against your spell save DC. On a failed save, the spell **dissipates with no effect**: the action, Bonus Action, or Reaction used to cast it is wasted. If the spell was cast with a spell slot, the slot is **not expended**.

🎲 Quick summary:

1. You see a creature within 60 ft cast a spell with a V, S, or M component: you use your **Reaction**.
2. The creature makes a **Constitution** save against **your spell save DC**.
3. Failure: the spell **dissipates**, its action is wasted, and its slot is not expended.
4. Success: the spell is cast normally. Your level 3 slot is expended.

⚠ Change from 2014

In 2014, Counterspell automatically countered a spell of level 3 or lower, and required a spellcasting ability check for a higher-level spell. In 2024, it is a **Constitution saving throw** by the target.

⚠ Flaw in the rule and fixes Table rule

The text doesn't say whether you learn **which spell** is being cast, nor **when** during a long casting you can react. Fix: the DM announces before the game what the counter reveals and when it can be used.

💡 Narrative option: Table rule

The DM can describe the caster's words breaking off, the glow dying between their fingers, the spell unraveling in the air.

Step 1 – Spot the casting:

You see a creature within **60 ft** cast a spell that includes a Verbal, Somatic, or Material component.

Step 2 – Use the Reaction:

You cast Counterspell with a level 3 or higher slot. Component: **S** (Somatic). Your Reaction must be available.

Step 3 – The target defends:

The caster makes a **Constitution** save against **your spell save DC**.

Step 4 – Resolve:

Failure: the spell dissipates with no effect. The action (or Bonus Action, or Reaction) used is wasted. If the spell used a slot, it is not expended. **Success**: the spell is cast normally.

Example: Éloïse (Wizard, spell save DC 15) sees an enemy mage cast Fireball. She reacts with Counterspell. The mage (Constitution +2) rolls 9: 9 + 2 = 11, below 15, a failure. The spell dissipates, its action is wasted, and its slot is not expended.

COUNTERSPELL (5E, 2024 RULES) – Q&A AND DEBATE

⚠ Common questions:

Does a success stop everything?
No: if the target succeeds, its spell is cast normally, and your level 3 slot is expended.

Which DC do I use?
Your spell save DC (8 + Proficiency Bonus + spellcasting ability modifier).

Is the countered spell's slot lost?
No: if the spell was cast with a slot, it is not expended when the target fails.

Is the caster's action lost?
Yes: the action, Bonus Action, or Reaction used to cast the spell is wasted.

Can I counter a spell I don't see being cast?
No: you must see the creature cast the spell.

Do I need a Material component?
No: Counterspell's only component is Somatic.

Does a higher slot change anything?
The text gives no higher-level effect.

⚠ Debate points and table options:
Table rule

Spells without components
The trigger requires a Verbal, Somatic, or Material component. A spell cast with none (for example with the Sorcerer's Subtle Spell) can't be targeted. **Option**: follow the text; or let the DM allow the counter if the effect is visible.

Knowing the spell
The text doesn't say whether you learn the spell's name. **Option**: the DM says it; or an Intelligence (Arcana) check is needed (see the **Identifying a Spell** sheet); or you counter blind.

Countering a Counterspell
Counterspell is a spell with a Somatic component: another caster can counter it. **Option**: allow it, announcing that the chain resolves from last cast to first.

Long castings
For a spell cast over several minutes, the text doesn't say when you can react. **Option**: at any moment during the casting, as long as you see the caster.

Measuring the 60 ft
Range counts from you to the caster. **Option**: measure to the creature (its space), not to the spell's target.

⚠ Rule clarifications (answers found on the web, reworded):

Reaction during your turn
You can cast a spell as a Reaction during your own turn, but you can expend only one spell slot per turn: if you already used a slot, Counterspell isn't possible that turn.

Counterspell or Dispel
Counterspell is the only way to interrupt a spell during casting. A readied *Dispel Magic* works only after the spell has taken effect.

Hands and components
One free hand can serve both Somatic and Material components (or a focus).

These points remain open to discussion: your feedback is welcome to refine this sheet.

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